The Conversation-to-*Content Map*

Fifteen recurring questions from football development leaders, each with the conventional answer, where it breaks down in practice and a specific position you can publish.

For academy directors, coaching education founders, technical directors and independent consultants who want to publish clearly on what they already know.

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How to use this document

Each entry has three parts:

The question: how practitioners actually phrase it in conversation.

The conventional answer: what the coaching course teaches, what the standard advice says, what most practitioners already know.

What actually happens / Your position: where the conventional answer breaks down in practice, and a specific, publishable take grounded in evidence and direct experience.

The position is a starting point, not a script. Your specific environment, your specific players or coaches, your specific experience of the same problem. That is what makes it yours.

Academy directors

Questions 1–6

1. 'How do I make my sessions more player-centred without losing structure?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Player-centredness and structure are in tension.

You either run organised sessions or you give players freedom to explore.

Guided discovery versus direct instruction.

The coaching course presents them as a spectrum and asks you to move along it.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Research from Frontiers in Sports and Active Living (2023) examined coach education across the Swedish FA and found that even game-based task designs used on UEFA B courses prolonged inherited coaching beliefs. Coaches implementing player-centred approaches still reduced unpredictability in practice, which runs counter to what skill acquisition research recommends. The philosophy arrived. The transition mechanism didn't.

YOUR POSITION

The obstacle is the absence of a sequenced handover. Coaches who've run direct sessions for a decade need a named transition sequence. The bridge is: constrain the environment first, then constrain less. That sequence is teachable, observable and transferable. Practitioners who can describe it specifically (what they changed first, what they changed next, what they left alone) are writing content that thousands of coaches can't find anywhere else.

2. 'When should I deselect a player and how do I handle it well?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Deselect at the right developmental checkpoint.

Communicate clearly and kindly.

Give the player honest feedback.

Wish them well.

Follow the club's process.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

A 2022 qualitative study published in Frontiers in Sports and Active Living found that all four players interviewed reported being marginalised before their formal release, left out of starting line-ups, left out of squad communications, while still training with the club. The public exclusion in front of teammates produced shame and guilt. Players didn't tell their parents because they felt they'd let them down. The formal deselection conversation wasn't the problem. The two to four weeks before it were.

A 2025 study in the Journal of Applied Sport Psychology found that parents described release communication as bland and generic: coaches gave feedback that was neither transparent, specific nor individualised.

YOUR POSITION

The deselection process starts long before the conversation. Academy directors who've built a structured communication protocol for the weeks preceding a release decision (what gets said, when, by whom and how it's framed) are filling a near-total absence in public coaching discourse. The specific, practical detail of how to handle that period is publishable material that almost no one is writing about.

3. 'How do I measure player development beyond just football performance?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Use the FA Four Corner Model.

Track technical and tactical development, physical development, psychological development and social development.

Assess across all four at each phase.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Research published in the Journal of Sports Sciences (Harper et al., 2024) studied academy managers across the English Premier League and EFL. The finding: managers identified psychosocial skills and characteristics as key drivers of player progression but found a significant lack of agreement on which specific skills mattered and how to develop them systematically. Clubs knew the corners existed. They hadn't agreed what went inside them.

YOUR POSITION

The Four Corner Model is a categorisation tool. It names the areas. It doesn't tell you what observable behaviours belong in the psychological corner, what conversations belong in the social corner, or how you assess progress in either. Academy directors who've spent years working out what actually belongs in those corners (specific indicators, specific conversations, specific transfer conditions) are carrying knowledge that most coaches never see written down. The specificity is the post.

4. 'How do I build a development culture, not just a results culture?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Create psychological safety.

Give players permission to fail.

Reduce emphasis on winning at junior levels.

Talk about development, not outcomes.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

A 2025 study in Sport in Society examined children's well-being inside a Category One academy and identified three structural patterns: the organisation's prioritisation of future success over present well-being, the normalisation of accelerated adulthood and the burden placed on children to cope with pressures far ahead of their developmental stage. The language of development was present. The structure rewarded something different.

YOUR POSITION

Culture is downstream of structure. If selection criteria, team-sheet decisions and staff performance metrics all reward results, the psychological safety messaging is decorative. Academy directors who've redesigned the structural incentives (not the vocabulary, but the things they actually measure and reward) have a specific and rare story to tell. The question to publish: what did you change structurally and what did it produce?

5. 'How do I retain good coaches when bigger clubs can always outpay us?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Create a positive working environment.

Offer development opportunities.

Build loyalty and a sense of belonging.

Make the culture worth staying for.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Full-time coaches in Premier League and EFL academies grew from 250 at the EPPP's launch in 2012 to over 800 by 2024, according to Premier League data. The market for capable academy coaches is competitive and clubs relying on goodwill and development conversations alone lose them. In every programme I have seen retain good coaches on a constrained budget, the coaches describe the same thing: they were developing faster there than they would have at the club with more money.

YOUR POSITION

Retaining coaches comes down to one question: what does a coach learn in year two at your programme that they couldn't learn at the Category One with more money? Directors who can answer that specifically (the access, the accountability, the complexity of problems they get to solve) have a recruiting story that money can't easily beat. Most directors have it. Almost none have written it down.

6. 'How do I get buy-in from the first team when they don’t trust what the academy produces?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Build relationships with the first-team manager.

Present data on graduates.

Demonstrate value through first-team appearances.

Play the long game.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Premier League data shows the share of minutes allocated to academy graduates fell from 11.2% in 2021–22 to 6.2% in 2024–25, despite £22 million in annual workforce investment across professional academies. First-team managers operate under direct pressure to retain league status, and the structural incentive to trust and play academy products runs directly against that pressure. Relationship-building doesn't resolve a structural conflict of incentives.

YOUR POSITION

The buy-in problem is a governance problem. Directors who've found operational solutions (specific data-sharing agreements, showcase formats designed for first-team staff rather than for internal academy reporting, conversations that connect academy outputs to the first-team's own risk management) are working at a different level from those still trying to solve it with relationship coffees. The specific mechanisms are what to publish.

Coaching education founders

Questions 7–11

7. 'How do I differentiate my course from the UEFA licence pathway?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Emphasise practical application.

Highlight smaller cohort sizes.

Demonstrate your real-world focus.

Talk about what's missing from the official pathway and how you fill it.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Research from the Journal of Sports Sciences (Strudwick et al., 2024) found that practitioners believe formal coach education could better prepare them for the social, negotiated and contextual realities of delivering coaching in a real club environment. Most name what they offer. Almost none identify what the official pathway is structurally built to exclude.

YOUR POSITION

A UEFA B programme is a competence certification. It assesses whether a coach can demonstrate prescribed behaviours in an assessment environment. It wasn't designed to develop adaptive expertise, contextual judgment or the social navigation of a multidisciplinary staff under pressure. Independent educators who can name that structural constraint precisely (and show how their programme addresses it) are answering a different question from the one the official pathway poses. The distinction is the publishable position.

8. 'How do I get coaches to actually change their practice after the course, not just pass the assessment?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Make sessions practical.

Use reflective frameworks.

Include follow-up mentoring.

Design for application, not just assessment.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

The same Frontiers study (2023) that found game-based task designs on UEFA B courses prolonged inherited beliefs also identified the mechanism: socio-cultural influences created a system inertia that survived the course itself. Coaches returned to familiar contexts and familiar pressures, and the reflection framework that landed in the course didn't travel back to the training pitch.

YOUR POSITION

The transfer problem is a context problem. What coaches do in an assessment environment and what they do under pressure with their own players (in their club, with their staff watching, in front of parents) are structurally different. Educators who've designed specific mechanisms for that transition (practical prompts that get coaches applying the methodology in the first four weeks back in their club) are solving a problem the official pathway hasn't touched. The design of the post-course period is the publishable methodology.

9. 'How do I price my programme against the official pathway?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Research the market.

Calculate your delivery costs.

Set a premium that reflects your value.

Position above commodity, below the licence.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

The full UEFA coaching pathway costs approximately £20,000 end to end for a coach in England. The figure anchors the conversation for independent educators in one of two ways: go lower and compete on cost, or go higher and justify every pound against a credential most employers still require. Neither strategy requires the educator to engage with what the £20,000 actually buys: the specific knowledge transfer that changes practice.

YOUR POSITION

The more useful frame is substitution: what does this programme provide that the £20,000 pathway structurally can't? A coach paying for the official pathway is buying access to a credential that opens doors. The education that changes practice is largely incidental. Independent programmes that name what they substitute (specific gaps, specific outcomes, specific career trajectories that the licence alone doesn't produce) are answering a different question from the one the official pathway poses. Educators who can articulate that argument have a pricing story that doesn't depend on the market rate.

10. 'How do I build a course that works for coaches at different experience levels?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Tier the content.

Use differentiated tasks.

Build in choice or streaming options so experienced and less experienced coaches aren't held back by the same material.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Ashford et al. (2024, Frontiers in Sports and Active Living) documented a call from researchers for a shift away from measuring coaching quality against a checklist of prescribed competencies, toward identifying and developing adaptive expertise: what effective coaching actually looks, sounds and feels like in specific contexts. A first-year UEFA B holder and a 15-year academy lead are separated by contextual judgment: the ability to read situations they haven't encountered before. Tiered content can accelerate knowledge acquisition. Contextual judgment develops through sustained practice under real conditions, over years of coaching real players in real contexts.

YOUR POSITION

The experienced coach in your cohort is your best resource. Educators who've designed their programmes so experienced coaches contribute their contextual judgment to the learning environment (rather than being streamed away from less experienced coaches) produce better outcomes at every level. The design question is specific: what do you build into the structure that makes the experienced coach's presence an asset rather than something to manage around? The design is the methodology to publish.

11. 'How do I get coaches who've been on my course to become advocates?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Ask for testimonials.

Build an alumni community.

Stay in touch.

Create a community that keeps graduates talking to each other and coming back to your brand.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

The alumni who advocate for a programme share one specific thing: they can name something their practice does differently now. Advocacy comes from specific, nameable transformation. Alumni who can describe one concrete change in their practice become advocates for the course that produced it. The coaches who become genuine advocates can describe (to a colleague, in a conversation, without preparation) one thing their practice does differently because of the course. Most alumni can't.

YOUR POSITION

Advocacy is a post-course design problem. The coaches who become advocates are the ones who used something from the programme in a real session within 30 days and it worked. Educators who've built specific first-use protocols (structured prompts that get coaches applying the methodology under real conditions in the first month back) have an advocacy engine. The testimonial is the byproduct of the application. The design of the 30 days after the course is the publishable methodology.

Technical directors

Questions 12–13

12. 'How do I build a coherent philosophy across multiple age groups when every phase lead has their own approach?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Create a club philosophy document.

Run alignment sessions.

Get phase leads in the room together.

Build shared language across the pathway.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Research published in the Journal of Sports Sciences (2023) found that player development curricula across English academies are often devised based on perceived importance and subjective interpretation rather than consistent evidence-based frameworks. The finding confirms what most technical directors already recognise: curricula built on perceived importance rather than evidence. The cause of the alignment problem sits elsewhere: phase leads are typically assessed on their phase outcomes alone, without any measure of their contribution to a coherent development pathway. The incentive structure works against alignment regardless of what the philosophy document says.

YOUR POSITION

Alignment is a design problem. Technical directors who've restructured how phase leads are held accountable (specifically, what cross-phase indicators are visible to everyone and how individual phase success is defined in relation to the full pathway) have solved a problem most clubs are still trying to fix with annual away days. The specific structural changes are what to publish: what you made visible, what you measured and what changed when you did.

13. 'How do I make the case for a development philosophy to a board that only cares about first-team results?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Present data on academy graduates.

Make the commercial case.

Reference the financial returns from player sales.

Bring in external experts to validate the approach.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Premier League data shows £2.87 billion in transfer revenue generated from 587 academy graduates across 20 clubs since 2015. It also shows the share of Premier League minutes going to academy graduates fell from 11.2% to 6.2% in three years. The board that wants a commercial argument can get one from that data. The board that wants a sceptical argument can get one too. The data is available to everyone. It doesn't resolve the conversation.

YOUR POSITION

The board presentation fails when it tries to win an argument using data the board will interpret through its own incentive structure. Technical directors who've found ways to align the development philosophy with what the board is actually accountable for (squad cost ratio, risk reduction, sell-on value generation and wage bill sustainability) are having a structurally different conversation. The data is context, not argument. The board's own constraints are the argument. The reframe is the content.

Independent consultants

Questions 14–15

14. 'How do I establish credibility in a niche where relationships and reputation are everything?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Build your network.

Do excellent work.

Let your reputation spread through referrals and word of mouth.

Be patient. This industry moves slowly and trust takes time.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

B2B buyer research (Bain/Google) consistently finds that 80–90% of buyers start with a shortlist before they make first contact, and 90% choose from that shortlist. The relationship-and-reputation model works for the second conversation. The shortlist determines whether you're in the first one. In a niche where most practitioners don't publish, being the person who does consistently puts you on shortlists where your name would otherwise never come up.

YOUR POSITION

Credibility at the relationship level and credibility at the shortlist level are different mechanisms. The first requires time and access. The second requires a consistent public record of thinking on a specific set of problems. Independent consultants who've built that public record don't replace the relationship model. They make the first conversation easier, because the prospect already has a view of how they think before a handshake has happened. Publishing consistently is how you get into rooms you haven't been invited into yet.

15. 'How do I turn one-off consulting projects into ongoing relationships?'

THE CONVENTIONAL ANSWER

Deliver excellent work.

Stay in touch after the engagement ends.

Look for follow-on opportunities.

Position yourself as someone they keep working with, not a one-off hire.

WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS

Most development professionals in this space are invisible between engagements. There's no mechanism that keeps them in front of a client's thinking between the end of one project and the beginning of the next. Staying in touch means periodic emails or occasional coffees, both of which require scheduling and neither of which happens automatically. The relationship sits dormant unless one party initiates it.

YOUR POSITION

The gap between projects is where most consulting relationships decay. Consultants who publish consistently on the problems their clients navigate don't need to manufacture reasons to stay in touch. Every post on a topic the client is actively dealing with is a touchpoint that costs nothing and keeps you present. The client reads it in their feed between your engagements. When the next project surfaces, you're already in the conversation. The more useful question: what are you building between engagements that keeps you present without requiring an email?

You now have fifteen starting points. None of them require you to fabricate an opinion or invent a controversy. Each one maps to something practitioners in this space are already debating. You just haven't written your version of it yet.

Pick the question closest to your current work. Read the position. Rewrite it in your own words, with your own examples, from your own programme. Publish it.

If you'd rather have someone extract that knowledge and write it for you, that's what I do. I work with a small number of academy directors, coaching education founders, technical directors and independent consultants at any one time. If the timing is right, the fastest way to find out is a 30-minute call.

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